

My Teaching Philosophy

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As a second-generation teacher, I see education as a way to foster critical thinkers who view challenges as opportunities for innovation. My diverse classroom experience ranges from teaching elementary students to adult learners at the university level. I prioritize active learning strategies over traditional passive approaches. This involves hands-on projects, in-class discussions, and real-world case studies to encourage genuine engagement and understanding.

My journey in education began when I earned my teaching certification, which led me to my first role in elementary school. Here, I used an individualized teaching method that catered to my students' varying needs. This foundational experience was invaluable and paved the way for my subsequent transition to middle school, where I worked under the Nigerian Universal Basic Education Scheme. This program aimed to address the shortage of teachers in rural communities. In this challenging environment, where class sizes often exceeded fifty students, I adapted my teaching style to incorporate both the traditional lecture format and Inquiry-Based Learning methods when appropriate. This dual approach allowed me to engage students effectively, despite the constraints of large class sizes.

During my first undergraduate studies, I had the opportunity to teach English-language classes to adult Arab-speaking immigrants. Initially, I approached this task with some trepidation, as it marked my first experience working with adult learners. However, this role proved to be transformative. It offered profound insights into the importance of recognizing that no single teaching technique is universally applicable; diverse learners require tailored methods that resonate with their unique experiences, learning styles, and learning speed.

In 2022, I too became an immigrant in North Dakota, joining the PhD program in Biology at the University of North Dakota (UND). My previous teaching experiences helped prepare me for my role as a Graduate Teaching Assistant (GTA) in Biology. I have been a GTA in a range of lower- and upper-division Biology courses (Introductory Biology I and II, with labs; Cell Biology, with labs; and Genetics). I have sought additional training in Best Practices to enrich my skill set for working with a broad spectrum of learners across different settings. In my classrooms, I prioritize transparent assessment practices by utilizing clear rubrics that align with learning objectives. This clarity not only helps students comprehend what is expected of them but also reinforces their learning and fosters a supportive environment.

As a GTA and aspiring teaching faculty member, my aim is to facilitate students' understanding through open discussions and collaborative problem-solving. By creating space for meaningful dialogue, I strive to empower students to take ownership of their learning journeys, ultimately leading to enriching outcomes, such as increased critical thinking, participation in research opportunities, and engagement in ethical learning practices. My goal for my students is to help them build the skills and awareness they need to further their academic and professional aspirations.